

Resource: Tips for Incident Report Writing

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When you submit an Incident Report (IR), it becomes part of a formal, written record for the Office of Residence Life, the Dean of Students Office and the University as a whole. It can be requested for review by University staff as well as the student and their representatives. Therefore, please be sure to consider the following:

- Do not include your opinions about a resident or their behavior. Report just the **facts**.
 - Example - Opinion: The resident was non-compliant.
 - Example - Facts/Observations: Resident [Last Name] raised their voice with Public Safety Officers and repeatedly refused to sit down after multiple directives.
- Include **all relevant** facts about the incident - how you became aware of the situation, information about all involved parties, facts about the violation or situation. Be as objective and thorough as possible, and start off every incident report with the date/time. The IR should read as a moment-by-moment description of what occurred.
- When possible, use exact quotes from residents involved (especially when they are yelling, swearing, etc.).
- Write in the third-person voice. Instead of saying I/me, refer to yourself as RA Last Name (Example: RA Anderson or RA Jones). To avoid confusion about which person the report is referring to, try not to use pronouns for others and instead refer to them as Resident Last Name or Officer Last Name.
- If you realize you left something out after submitting the IR, misidentified someone or included anything else that needs to be corrected, **let your CD/GSA know as soon as possible**. If you can't confirm what you wrote - don't write it! Write the IR considering others will read it. Proof read for content as well as accuracy.
- **Check spelling, grammar, and sentence structure** - the basics you would correct on a paper. It is best to type the report in a word document first and copy/paste the narrative into Advocate.
- When Public Safety is involved, take down the last name of all officers involved and the report number. If you miss some information, you should ask the PS officers to fill in those missing details.
- You should submit this report as soon as possible and **definitely before you go to bed for the night. Do not wait until morning to submit it.**
- If you have notes with ID numbers and other sensitive information, give them to your CD/GSA and they will shred that information
- You will be submitting your incident reports on a website called Advocate. [\(Click this link to go to Advocate. \(Links to an external site.\)\)](https://stthomas-Advocate) (<https://stthomas-Advocate>)

advocate.symplicity.com/index.php/pid746599?s=home&mode=list&tab=list&tabmode=list) It is a good idea to save it as a bookmark on your computer.

Common IR Writing Mistakes:

Correct:

Smelled

Public Safety

Marijuana or THC

Residents/Students

Intoxicated

Residence Hall

Description of actions

Incorrect:

Smelt

Pub Safe

Weed

Residence

Drunk

Dorm

Summary/judgement of actions